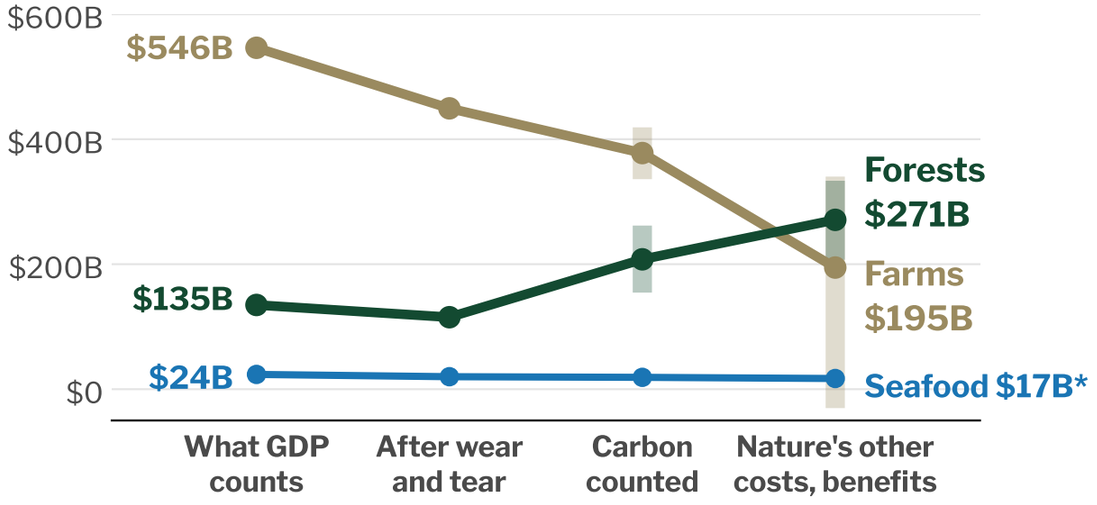
U.S. forests give back about twice what the economy records, and wood not grown here is cut somewhere else

UNDERVALUED

Count what forests give, and they rival farms

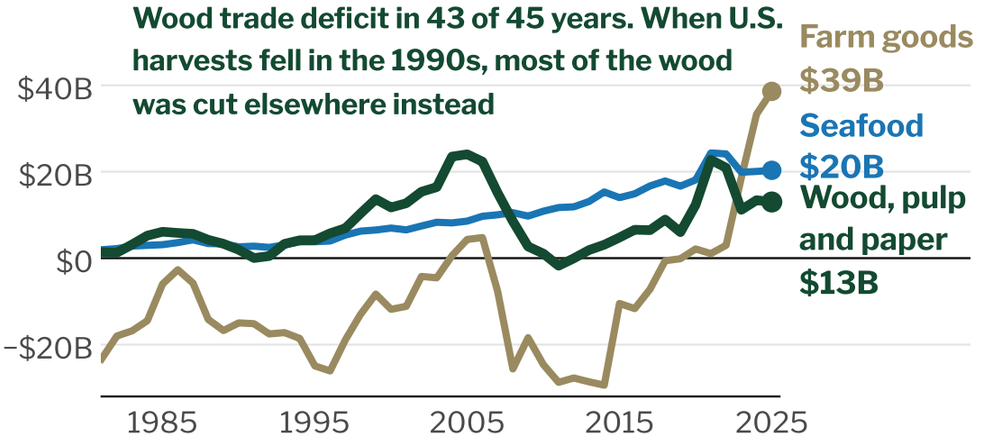
Yearly value in 2022, adding what markets do not price



MISUNDERSTOOD

The U.S. buys more wood products than it sells

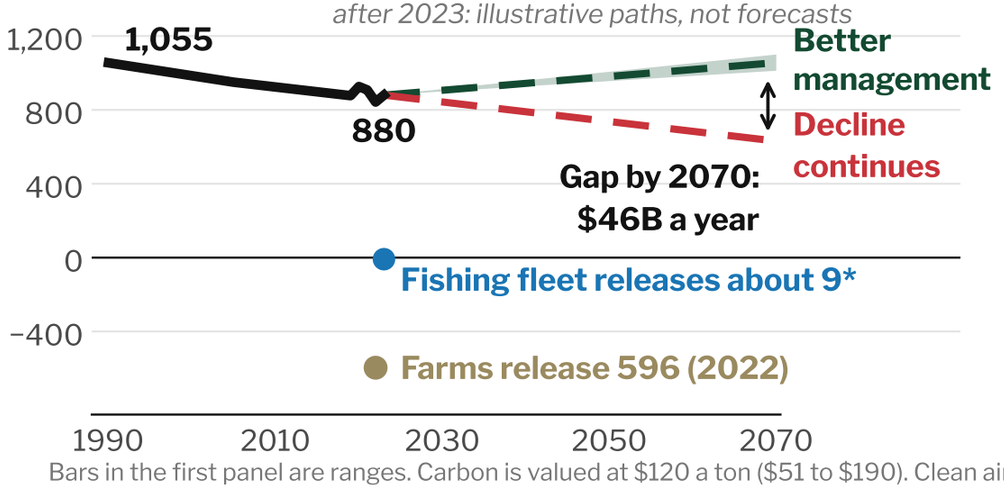
Imports minus exports, $B a year (below zero is a surplus)



AT RISK

Forests absorb carbon, but the sink is shrinking

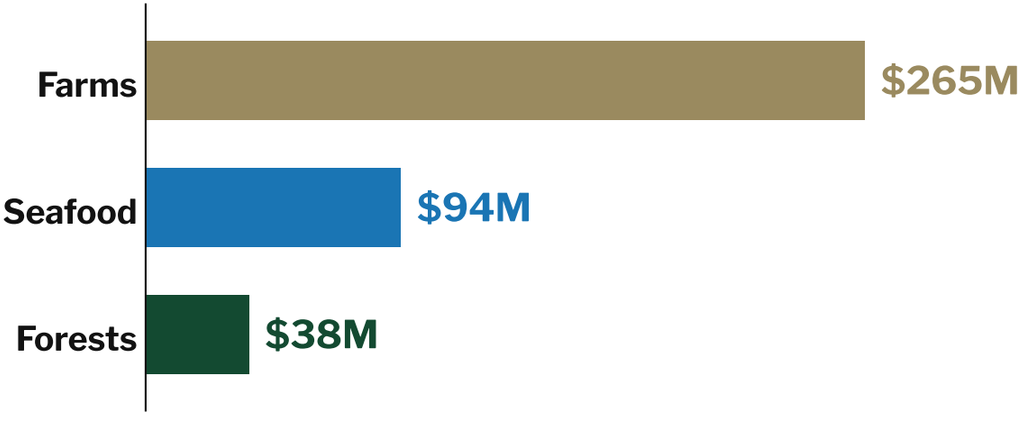
Carbon dioxide stored (above zero) or released (below), million tons a year



UNDERINVESTED

Forest research gets a seventh of farm research

Federal formula funds to university research, fiscal 2024



Bars in the first panel are ranges. Carbon is valued at $120 a ton ($51 to $190). Clean air covers all U.S. trees. Water and recreation cover national forests only.

*Seafood estimates are rough. Fleet fuel emissions use a global intensity (Parker et al. 2018), and lost fishing income is scaled from the World Bank's Sunken Billions.

EPA's inventory begins in 1990. Sources: BEA, EPA, FAO, UN Comtrade, USDA, NOAA, Cavender-Bares et al. (2022), Daigneault et al. (2024).

Methods and data: github.com/holoros/conversation-forest-value. Chart: Weiskittel, Daigneault and Woodall, University of Maine.